

COVID-19 (Coronavirus Disease)

What is COVID-19?

COVID-19 is an infectious respiratory illness caused by the SARS-CoV-2 coronavirus. It spreads primarily through respiratory droplets and aerosols from infected people.

Most people experience mild to moderate illness. Older adults and those with comorbidities (diabetes, heart disease, immunocompromised) are at higher risk of severe disease.

Symptoms

Common symptoms: fever, cough, fatigue, loss of taste or smell, sore throat, headache, body aches, runny nose, diarrhea.

Severe symptoms requiring urgent care: difficulty breathing, persistent chest pain or pressure, confusion, inability to stay awake, bluish lips or face.

Long COVID symptoms (lasting weeks-months): fatigue, brain fog, shortness of breath, joint pain, depression.

Medicines

Mild cases: rest, hydration, paracetamol for fever. Isolation for at least 5 days.

Antiviral medications for high-risk patients: nirmatrelvir-ritonavir (Paxlovid), remdesivir, or molnupiravir — must be started within 5 days of symptoms.

Severe cases: dexamethasone (corticosteroid) reduces mortality in hospitalized patients needing oxygen.

Anticoagulants are used to prevent blood clots in hospitalized patients.

There is NO role for antibiotics unless a bacterial superinfection is confirmed.

Emergency Actions

Seek emergency care if: SpO₂ drops below 94%, breathing becomes labored, persistent chest pain, confusion.

Monitor oxygen levels at home with a pulse oximeter if available.

In COVID pneumonia: prone positioning (lying face down) can improve oxygenation at home.

Call 112 if the patient becomes unresponsive or stops breathing normally.

What You Should Do

Stay up to date with COVID-19 vaccinations and boosters.

Wear well-fitted masks in crowded indoor settings.

Isolate if tested positive to prevent spread to others.

Maintain good ventilation indoors. Wash hands frequently.

Seek medical care early if symptoms worsen, especially if you have risk factors.